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United States Patent

12407564

Kind Code

B2

Date of Patent

September 02, 2025

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Identifying and marking failed egress links in data plane

Abstract

A method of identifying a failed egress path of a hardware forwarding element. The method detects an egress link failure in a data plane of the forwarding element. The method generates a link failure signal in the data plane identifying the failed egress link. The method generates a packet that includes the identification of the egress link based on the link failure signal. The method sets the status of the egress link to failed in the data plane based on the identification of the egress link in the generated packet.

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Family ID: 63208312

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Appl. No.: 18/495590

Filed: October 26, 2023

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20240056348 A1	Feb. 15, 2024

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17723243 20220418 ABANDONED child-doc US 18495590
continuation parent-doc US 16903305 20200616 US 11310099 20220330 child-doc US 17723243
continuation parent-doc US 16048202 20180727 ABANDONED child-doc US 16903305
continuation parent-doc US 15150015 20160509 US 10063407 20180828 child-doc US 16048202
us-provisional-application US 62292498 20160208

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: H04L41/0677 (20220101); H04L41/0654 (20220101); H04L45/28 (20220101); H04L45/42 (20220101); H04L45/64 (20220101); H04L45/745 (20220101); H04L49/00 (20220101); H04L49/55 (20220101); H04L69/22 (20220101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC H04L41/0677 (20130101); H04L41/0654 (20130101); H04L45/28 (20130101); H04L45/42 (20130101); H04L45/64 (20130101); H04L45/745 (20130101); H04L49/3063 (20130101); H04L49/555 (20130101); H04L69/22 (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: H04L (41/0677); H04L (41/0654); H04L (45/28); H04L (45/42); H04L (45/64); H04L (45/745); H04L (49/3063); H04L (49/555); H04L (69/22); Y02D (30/50)

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Background/Summary

CLAIM OF PRIORITY (1) This application is a continuation of prior co-pending U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/723,243, filed Apr. 18, 2022 and titled "IDENTIFYING AND MARKING FAILED EGRESS LINKS IN DATA PLANE," which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/903,305, filed Jun. 16, 2020 and titled "IDENTIFYING AND MARKING FAILED EGRESS LINKS IN DATA PLANE," now U.S. Pat. No. 11,310,099, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/048,202, filed Jul. 27, 2018 and titled "IDENTIFYING AND MARKING FAILED EGRESS LINKS IN DATA PLANE," which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/150,015, filed May 9, 2016 and titled "IDENTIFYING AND MARKING FAILED EGRESS LINKS IN DATA PLANE," now U.S. Pat. No. 10,063,407, which claims the benefit of prior U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 62/292,498, filed Feb. 8, 2016 and titled "IDENTIFYING AND MARKING FAILED EGRESS LINKS IN DATA PLANE." Each of the aforesaid prior Patent Applications is hereby incorporated herein by reference in its entirety.

BACKGROUND

- (1) A forwarding element such as a switch or a router can often send packets to a destination through several different egress paths. The forwarding elements utilize different algorithms to identify the best path to send the packets to optimize network congestion as well as transmission time.
- (2) Once one of these egress paths fails, the forwarding element has to get notified that the path has

failed and mark the path as failed in order to avoid forwarding packets on the failed path. A path may fail due to a port or a wire failure inside the forwarding element or due to a path failure several hops away between the forwarding element and a packet destination.

(3) A typical solution to keep track of the failed paths is using software in the control plane of the forwarding element to keep track of the status of the configured paths and mark a path as failed as soon as the path becomes unavailable. Utilizing software to keep track of and update the list of failed paths is, however, slow. Depending on the load of the processor that is executing the software, marking a path as failed by software may take several milliseconds. Such a delay is not desirable and can cause significant delays in a high-speed forwarding element.

BRIEF SUMMARY

(4) Some embodiments provide a hardware forwarding element (e.g., a hardware switch or a hardware router) with a novel packet-processing pipeline that quickly marks a failed egress path by performing a set of hardware and firmware operations in the data plane. The forwarding element in some embodiments includes an ingress pipeline, a traffic manager, and an egress pipeline. Each one of the ingress and egress pipelines includes a pipeline with a parser, a match-action unit (MAU), and a deparser.

(5) The parser receives the packets coming into the pipeline and produces a packet header vector (PHV) as its output. The PHV provides the input data to the match tables of the MAU. The MAU includes a set of match-action stages. Each of these stages matches a particular set of header fields included in the PHV against a match table and takes an action based on the result of the match. The output PHV is then handed to the deparser, which reassembles the packet by putting back together the output PHV and the payload of the packet that the deparser receives directly from the parser.

(6) The forwarding element also includes a packet generator that is capable of generating packets inside the forwarding element and placing them in the packet pipeline. The packet generator receives the identification of failed paths or ports. For instance, when a port or a wire inside the forwarding element fails, some embodiments generate an interrupt that provides the identification of the failed port (or path). The packet generator in some embodiments also utilizes mechanisms such as keep alive to determine failed paths that are several hops away. Once the packet generator receives the identification of a failed link (i.e., a failed port or a failed path), the packet generator generates a packet that includes the identification of the failed link in a predetermined location in the packet header. The packet goes through the MAU pipeline and matches a predefined match field. The action corresponding to the match field causes an action unit in the forwarding element to use the failed link identification and compute an index to the status bit of the failed link in a data structure and to set the status bit to off (i.e., to indicate that the link has failed).

(7) Some embodiments utilize a process to mark an egress link (i.e., a path or a port) as failed by performing a set of operations that are done by dedicated hardware and firmware in the data plane of the forwarding element. The process receives an indication that an egress link (i.e., a path or a port) of the forwarding element has failed. The process then generates a packet inside the forwarding element and includes an identification of the failed link (i.e., the failed path or port) in a predetermined field of the packet header.

(8) The process then places the packet in the packet pipeline of the forwarding element. The process then parses the packet and places the identification of the failed link in a register of the PHV and forwards the PHV to the MAU. The process matches the identification of the failed link in the PHV with the match field of a match-action entry that is preprogrammed to match the link's identification. Each match field has a corresponding action.

(9) Once the identification of the failed link matches a match field, the process uses an arithmetic logic unit (ALU) to perform the corresponding action of the match-action entry. The process determines the location of the link's status bit in a data structure (e.g., a link status table or a port status table) that keeps track of live and failed links. The process sets the bit at the determined location to off (or failed). The data structure is stored in a dual port memory that is capable of being

written directly by hardware. Once the status bit of the failed link is updated, the packet is no longer needed and is dropped.

(10) The preceding Summary is intended to serve as a brief introduction to some embodiments of the invention. It is not meant to be an introduction or overview of all inventive subject matter disclosed in this document. The Detailed Description that follows and the Drawings that are referred to in the Detailed Description will further describe the embodiments described in the Summary as well as other embodiments. Accordingly, to understand all the embodiments described by this document, a full review of the Summary, Detailed Description and the Drawings is needed. Moreover, the claimed subject matters are not to be limited by the illustrative details in the Summary, Detailed Description and the Drawing.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) The novel features of the invention are set forth in the appended claims. However, for purposes of explanation, several embodiments of the invention are set forth in the following figures.
- (2) FIG. 1 conceptually illustrates a block diagram of a hardware forwarding element and a block diagram of an ingress/egress pipeline of the hardware forwarding element in some embodiments.
- (3) FIG. 2 illustrates ECMP routing for forwarding packets from a forwarding element to a destination over several different paths.
- (4) FIG. 3 illustrates link aggregation as another example of forwarding packets from a forwarding element to a destination over several different paths.
- (5) FIG. 4A conceptually illustrates a logical view of a vector that shows the status of the egress links of a forwarding element in some embodiments.
- (6) FIG. 4B conceptually illustrates an implementation of the logical vector of FIG. 4A.
- (7) FIG. 5 conceptually illustrates a block diagram of a hardware forwarding element that is capable of marking failed links by performing a set of hardware operations in the data plane in some embodiments.
- (8) FIG. 6 conceptually illustrates a portion of a hardware forwarding element used for detecting a port failure and reporting the failure to the packet generator in some embodiments.
- (9) FIG. 7 conceptually illustrates a grid of unit memories in some embodiments.
- (10) FIG. 8 conceptually illustrates a process for assigning status bits to a forwarding element's egress links and programming match-action entries to set the status of a failed link to failed.
- (11) FIG. 9 conceptually illustrates the steps that the hardware forwarding element of FIG. 5 takes to mark a failed link in data plane in some embodiments.
- (12) FIG. 10 conceptually illustrates a process that a forwarding element performs in data plane in order set the status of a failed link to failed in some embodiments.
- (13) FIG. 11 conceptually illustrates a process that a forwarding element performs in the data plane in order to set the status of a failed link to failed in some embodiments.
- (14) FIG. 12 conceptually illustrates a port status table of some embodiments maintained in dual port memory that is writable by hardware.
- (15) FIG. 13 conceptually illustrates a process for assigning backup egress ports for a forwarding element and programming match-action entries to set the status of a failed port to failed.
- (16) FIG. 14 conceptually illustrates the steps a hardware forwarding element takes to mark a failed port in the data plane in some embodiments.
- (17) FIG. 15 conceptually illustrates the steps a hardware forwarding element takes to replace a failed primary egress port with a backup port in the data plane in some embodiments.
- (18) FIG. 16 conceptually illustrates a process that a forwarding element performs in the data plane in order to set the status of a failed port to failed in some embodiments.

(19) FIG. 17 conceptually illustrates an electronic system with which some embodiments of the invention are implemented.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(20) In the following detailed description of the invention, numerous details, examples, and embodiments of the invention are set forth and described. However, it will be clear and apparent to one skilled in the art that the invention is not limited to the embodiments set forth and that the invention may be practiced without some of the specific details and examples discussed.

(21) Software defined networks (SDNs) decouple the data and control planes. The data plane, which is also referred to as forwarding plane or user plane, is the part of the network that carries data packets (i.e., user packets) traffic. In contrast, the control plane in a network controls signaling traffic and routing.

(22) In a forwarding element (e.g., a hardware switch or a hardware router), the data plane is the part of the architecture that decides what to do with the packets that arrive at the ingress interface. The data plane of a forwarding element is implemented by hardware and firmware while the control plane is implemented in software to provide for a more flexible management of network components from a central location. Keeping track of failed paths by the software in the control plane could, however, be time consuming and slow.

(23) Some embodiments provide a hardware forwarding element with a novel packet-processing pipeline that quickly marks a failed egress link by performing a set of hardware operations in the data plane. In the following discussions, the term link is used to refer to a path or a port. The hardware forwarding element of some embodiments includes, among other elements, an ingress pipeline and an egress pipeline. Each of these pipelines includes a parser, a match-action unit (MAU), and a deparser.

(24) FIG. 1 conceptually illustrates a block diagram of a hardware forwarding element **105** and a block diagram of an ingress or egress pipeline **145** of the hardware forwarding element in some embodiments. As shown, the forwarding element **105** includes an ingress pipeline (or data path) **110**, a traffic manager **115**, and an egress pipeline **120**.

(25) The traffic manager **115** has several components such as a queuing and buffering system, a packet replicator, and a port failure feedback generator. These components are described further below. The ingress pipeline **110** receives packets **125** from a set of channels (e.g., through a set of I/O modules), parses each packet header into a packet header vector (PHV), sends the PHV through a set of match and action stages which may modify the PHV, deparses the packet headers back from the PHV into packet format, and queues the packet in a centralized data buffer (i.e., a data buffer provided by the traffic manager **115**). Each one of these operations is described in more detail below by reference to the pipeline **145**. The block diagram of both the ingress pipeline **110** and the egress pipeline **120** is similar to the pipeline **145**.

(26) In some embodiments, the traffic manager **115** receives the packets that are processed by the ingress pipeline and provides a large shared buffer (storage) that accommodates the queuing delays due to oversubscription of the output channels of the ingress deparser. In some embodiments, the data buffer stores packet data, while pointers to that data are kept in different queues per channel. Each channel in turn requests data from the common data buffer using a configurable queuing policy. When pointers to packets reach the head of the queues, the packets are read out of the data buffer of the traffic manager **115** into the egress pipeline **120**.

(27) The egress pipeline **120** receives the packets from the traffic manager **115**. The parser in egress pipeline separates the packet payload from the packet headers, stores the packets headers in a PHV, sends the PHV through a set of match and action stages, deparses the packet headers back from the PHV into packet format, and sends the packets **130** to an appropriate output port of the forwarding element **105** to be driven off the forwarding element (e.g., through one of the output channels). An output packet may be the same packet as the corresponding input packet (i.e., with identical packet headers), or it may have different packet headers compared to the input packet based on the actions

that are applied to the packet headers in the ingress and egress pipelines (e.g., different header field values for certain header fields and/or different sets of header fields).

(28) It should be understood that the illustrated blocks in forwarding element **105** are exemplary only. The ingress, traffic manager, and egress blocks are simplified for ease of description. For example, although the figure shows only one entry point to the ingress parser and one exit point from the egress deparser, in some embodiments the input signals are received by many different input channels (e.g., 64 channels) and the output signals are sent out of the forwarding element from different output channels (e.g., 64 channels). Additionally, although for the illustrated forwarding element only one parser interface is shown for the ingress/egress pipeline **145**, some embodiments employ numerous parser blocks (e.g., 16 parser blocks) that feed a match-action unit (MAU) in each pipeline.

(29) FIG. **1** also shows a block diagram **145** of an interface of the hardware forwarding element **105**. Each one of the ingress **110** and egress **120** pipelines use an interface similar to the interface **145**. The interface includes a pipeline with three different units, namely a parser unit **150**, an MAU **155**, and a deparser unit **160**. The parser **150** of some embodiments receives the incoming packets and produces a packet header vector (PHV) as its output. In other words, the parser **150** separates the packet headers from the packet payload by extracting different fields of packet headers and storing them in the PHV.

(30) In some embodiments the PHV includes a set of different size registers or containers. For instance, in some embodiments the PHV includes sixty-four 8-bit registers, ninety-six 16-bit registers, and sixty-four 32-bit registers (for a total of 224 registers containing 4096 bits). Other embodiments may have any different numbers of registers of different sizes. In some embodiments, the parser **150** stores each extracted packet header in a particular subset of one or more registers of the PHV. For example, the parser might store a first header field in one 16-bit register and a second header field in a combination of an 8-bit register and a 32-bit register (e.g., if the header field is 36 bits long).

(31) The PHV provides the input data to the match tables of the MAU. In some embodiments the MAU **155** includes a set of match-action stages (e.g., 32 match-action stages). Each of these stages matches a particular set of header fields against a match table and takes an action based on the result of the match (e.g., assigning the packet to an output port and queue, dropping the packet, modifying one or more of the header fields, etc.). Based on the actions taken on different header data during the different stages of the MAU **155**, the PHV that the MAU outputs might include the same header data as the PHV that the MAU received from the parser, or the output PHV might contain different data than the input PHV.

(32) The output PHV is then handed to the deparser **160**. The deparser **160** reassembles the packet by putting back together the output PHV (that might or might not have been modified) that the deparser receives from the MAU **155** and the payload of the packet that the deparser receives directly from the parser **150**. The deparser then sends the packets **140** out of the ingress/egress pipeline (to the traffic manager **115** or out of the forwarding element, depending on whether it is the deparser for the ingress pipeline or the egress pipeline).

(33) I. Identifying and Marking Failed Links in Data Plane

(34) Forwarding a packet from a forwarding element to a destination that is several hops away can often be done over several different paths. Once a path is determined to have failed, an alternative path with the same cost (or a path with the least possible cost) is selected to replace the failed path. One such example is equal-cost multi-path (ECMP) routing. Another example is link aggregation (LAG).

(35) A. Forwarding the Packets using ECMP

(36) ECMP is a routing strategy that selects the next hop for forwarding a packet to the final destination in such a way to minimize the overall cost (e.g., the required time or the network congestion) for forwarding the packet to the final destination. FIG. **2** illustrates ECMP routing for

forwarding packets from a forwarding element **205** to a destination **210** over several different paths through several hops **240-260** that can also be forwarding elements. The figure is shown in two stages **201** and **202**. The cost of sending a packet through each path is written next to the path. (37) As shown, there are several paths such as A-B-E-G, A-C-E-G, and A-D-F-G between source A **205** and destination G **210** that cost 6 units. Each one of these paths is, e.g., a separate open system interconnection (OSI) Layer 3 (L3) path where packets can be sent through. In stage **201** the path A-B-E-G (as shown by arrow **215**) is utilized to send packets for one or more flows between source A **205** and destination G **210**. As shown, multiple paths can be on the same OSI Layer 2 (L2) port of a forwarding element. For instance, in FIG. 2, both paths A-C-E-G and A-C-G are on port **230** of forwarding element **205**.

(38) In stage **202**, the path between hops B **240** and E **245** fails. According to ECMP strategy, another route between the source **205** and the destination **210** is selected to keep the transmission cost at a minimum. As shown, forwarding element A **205** selects the path A-C-E-G **220** to replace path **215**.

(39) B. Forwarding the Packets using LAG

(40) FIG. 3 illustrates LAG as another example of forwarding packets from a forwarding element to a destination over several different paths. LAG combines multiple network connections in parallel to provide throughput and redundancy. The figure is shown in two stages **301** and **302**. The cost of sending a packet through a path is written next to each path. As shown, there are several paths between forwarding element A **305** and hop B **330** (which could be another forwarding element) that have equal cost. These paths, e.g., use OSI Layer 2 (L2) ports on forwarding element **305** that are on one logical channel bundle. These paths provide parallelism to increase throughput as well as redundancy.

(41) As shown in stage **301**, the path A-B-D-E **315**, which passes through path **335** between port **340** of forwarding element **305** and hop **330** is used to pass packets for one or more flows from forwarding element A **305** to destination E **310**. In stage **302** port **340** fails. As a result, link **335** becomes inaccessible. As shown, another path **320** (which includes the link **345** between port **350** of forwarding element **305** and hop **330**) is selected to replace the failed path **315**.

(42) In addition to the examples of ECMP and LAG, it is possible that several tunnels go through the same egress port of the forwarding element. Even if the port remains functional, one of the tunnels may fail several hops away downstream. Similar to the examples of FIGS. 2 and 3, the failed path has to be replaced with another path despite the fact that the egress port is still operational.

(43) C. Link Status Table

(44) Some embodiments maintain the status of each egress link of a forwarding element in a data structure that includes a flag (e.g., one bit) per link. The value of the bit indicates whether the corresponding link is up or down. For instance in some embodiments a value of 1 indicates that the corresponding link is operational and a value of 0 indicates that the corresponding link is down. In other embodiments, a value of 0 may be used to indicate that a link is operational and a value of 1 to indicate a link is down.

(45) FIG. 4A conceptually illustrates a logical view of a data structure (e.g. a vector) that shows the status of the egress links of a forwarding element in some embodiments. As shown, vector **405** is an array of n bits. Each bit corresponds to a configured egress link (i.e., a port or a path) of the forwarding element. The status of each link is represented by the value of the corresponding bit. When a link is up and operational, the corresponding bit is set to on (e.g., is set to 1) to indicate that the link is live. On the other hand, when a link is down, the corresponding bit is set to off (e.g., is set to 0) to indicate that that link has failed and is not available. Vector **405** in some embodiments is stored in memory as a group of one or more words.

(46) FIG. 4B conceptually illustrates an implementation of the logical vector **405** of FIG. 4A. As shown, some embodiments utilize a link status table in an area of memory **410** (referred to herein

as the live link vector table) for storing the status of the links. The memory used to store table **410** in some embodiments is a dual port memory that is capable of being read and written by hardware. The dual port memory is also capable of being written by software. In contrast, a random access memory (RAM) is read by hardware but is written only by software. For instance the software writes into a buffer, which is in turn transferred into the RAM.

(47) The dual port memory used to store the live link vector table **410** in some embodiments is implemented from single port static random-access memory (SRAM) units. These embodiments utilize a map RAM (e.g., a small SRAM of 1024 entries by 11 bits) for each unit SRAM. The map RAM stores whether the corresponding unit SRAM has the most up to date data for a memory address. Simultaneous read and write operations are performed as follows.

(48) The read operation is performed by (1) presenting the address to read to all map RAMs, (2) the map RAM with the data to be read signals that its associated unit (e.g., SRAM S1) holds the most up to date data, (3) the unit SRAM S1 is read at the corresponding address. Since the write operation cannot be performed with the same unit where the data currently resides (because the single port of SRAM S1 is occupied by a read), the write is performed by (1) querying the map RAMs to determine which unit SRAM is not busy and has the specified address available for write operation, (2) writing the data to the free SRAM (e.g. SRAM S2), (3) updating the map RAM associated with unit SRAM S2 to indicate unit SRAM S2 has the most up to date version of the data, and (4) updating the map RAM associated with unit SRAM S1 to indicate the address in SRAM S1 is now available for write operations (since the data in SRAM S1 is now stale).

(49) As shown, table **410** includes several groups of live link vectors. Each group is being used by one application (or one user). For instance, group **415** includes several live link vectors (e.g., 128 bits each). Group **415** maintains the status of the links used by one application that utilizes a forwarding element such as forwarding element **105** in FIG. 1.

(50) Once a link such as path **215** in FIG. 2 or port **340** in FIG. 3 fails, a typical solution in prior art forwarding elements is for software in control plane to mark the link as failed and select an alternative link to replace the failed link. Utilizing software to mark a link as failed and determine a replacement link is, however, time consuming and slow. For instance, marking the link as failed by software may take several milliseconds. Accordingly, some embodiments provide a technique to quickly mark a failed link by performing a set of hardware operations in the data link (e.g., in the order of a few microseconds) and route packets to an alternative link without software involvement.

(51) D. Detecting and Marking a Failed Link

(52) FIG. 5 conceptually illustrates a block diagram of a hardware forwarding element **505** that is capable of marking failed links by performing a set of hardware operations in the data plane in some embodiments. As shown, in addition to ingress pipeline **110**, traffic manager **115**, and egress pipeline **120**, the forwarding element includes a packet generator **510**. The packet generator is capable of generating packets internally in the forwarding element and sending the packets through the packet pipeline. As shown, the ingress packets **125** are received at the ingress pipeline **110** through a set of ingress ports **545** while packets **515** that are generated by the packet generator are received at the ingress pipeline at a separate port **520**.

(53) As shown, packet generator **510** receives the identification **525** of failed links. For instance, when a forwarding element's port fails, some embodiments generate an interrupt that provides the identification of the failed port. The interrupt is used to provide the identification of the failed port to the packet generator. As another example, the packet generator may receive an identification of a failed path (such as path **215** in FIG. 2) when a portion of the path that is several hops away fails. For instance, the packet generator receives a hardware signal when the failure of a keep alive signal indicates a portion of an egress path has failed.

(54) FIG. 6 conceptually illustrates a portion of a hardware forwarding element used for detecting a port failure and reporting the failure to the packet generator in some embodiments. The figure

shows traffic manager **115**, several ingress pipelines **621-624** (each pipeline similar to pipeline **110** in FIG. 5), several egress pipelines **631-634** (each pipeline similar to pipeline **120** in FIG. 5), and several packet generators **611-614** (each packet generator similar to packet generator **510** in FIG. 5). Each packet generator **611-614** is associated with one ingress pipeline **621-624**. For instance, packet generator **611** is associated with ingress pipeline **621**.

(55) The figure also shows several media access control (MAC) units **601-604** to monitor ingress and egress ports. In some embodiments, one MAC unit is utilized for monitoring both the ingress and the egress ports of a pipeline. For instance, the blocks labeled MAC unit **601** next to the ingress pipeline **621** and the egress pipeline **631** are one MAC unit which are shown in FIG. 6 as two separate blocks for clarity. In other embodiments, separate MAC units are utilized to monitor the ingress and egress ports of each pipeline. Once an egress port fails, the corresponding MAC unit **601-604** informs traffic manager **115** using a hardware signal (as conceptually shown by arrow **660**).

(56) As shown, traffic manager **115** has several components: a queuing and buffering system **645**, a packet replicator **650**, and a failure feedback generator **640**. As described above, the queuing and buffering system provides a large shared buffer that accommodates the queuing delays due to oversubscription of the output channels of the ingress deparser. Port failure feedback generator **640** receives a hardware signal from the MAC unit that detects a port failure.

(57) In the example of FIG. 6, MAC unit **601** detects that the egress port (not shown) being monitored by the MAC unit has failed. MAC unit **601** sends a signal **660** to the port failure feedback generator **640**. The port failure feedback generator **640** in turn generates a hardware signal (as conceptually shown by arrow **670**) to the packet generator **611** connected to the ingress pipeline **621** and egress pipeline **631** that are associated with the failed port. The hardware signal includes the identification of the failed port. For instance the port failure feedback generator in some embodiments identifies the failed port based on which MAC unit has reported the failure. In other embodiments, the signal from a MAC unit (e.g., a MAC unit that monitors several ports) to the failure feedback generator includes an identification of the failed port (e.g., in the form of an n bit of information that uniquely identifies the failed port). The failure feedback generator then sends a signal to the packet generator and includes the identification of the failed port (e.g., in the form of an m bit of information that uniquely identifies the failed port).

(58) The packet generator **611** then generates a packet **670** that is placed in ingress pipeline **621**. As described below, the packet **670** cause the status bit corresponding the failed port to be set to off. All actions of detecting that a port has failed by a MAC unit (such as MAC unit **601**), sending a signal from the MAC unit to the traffic manager **115**, sending a signal from the traffic manager to a packet generator (such as packet generator **611**), generating a packet (such as packet **670**) by the packet generator, and setting the status bit of the failed port to off are done by hardware and firmware in the data plane of the forwarding element without using the control plane or software.

(59) Referring back to FIG. 5, the figure shows one of the ingress pipeline, egress pipeline, and packet generators of FIG. 6. Once the packet generator **510** receives the identification of a failed link, the packet generator generates a packet **515** that includes the identification of the failed link in a predetermined location in the packet header. The packet goes through the MAU match-action stages and matches a predefined match field. The action corresponding to the match field causes a preprogrammed action unit in the forwarding element to use the failed link identification and compute an index to the status bit of the failed link in the live link vector table and to set the bit to off (i.e., to indicate that the link has failed).

(60) The hardware forwarding element of some embodiments processes network packets according to a series of match-action tables that specify when to perform certain operations on the packets. The match-action tables include match entries that specify sets of match conditions that can be met by packets, and corresponding action entries that specify operations to perform on packets that meet the match conditions.

(61) As an example, the match entry of a match-action table might match on the identification of a failed link. The corresponding action entry might specify that the status bit of the link in the live link vector table has to be set to off. As another example, a match-action table might match on the destination address of an ingress packet and specify an output port to which to send the packet. Different destination addresses (i.e., different match entries) correspond to output actions to different ports (i.e., different action entries) of the forwarding element.

(62) In some embodiments, the forwarding element includes a set of unit memories (e.g., SRAM and/or ternary content-addressable memory (TCAM)). The unit memories implement a match-action table by having a first set of the unit memories store the match entries and a second set of the unit memories store the action entries. That is, for a particular match entry and the corresponding action entry, the match entry is stored in a first unit memory and the action entry is stored in a second unit memory.

(63) Some embodiments arrange the unit memories in a grid of rows and columns, with horizontal and vertical routing resources that connects the unit memories to arithmetic logic units (ALUs), also referred to as action units, that read the data from the unit memories in order to perform the match and action operations. In some such embodiments, a first pool of unit memories within a grid (e.g., a set of one or more columns of the grid) are utilized for the match entries, and a second pool of unit memories within the grid are utilized for the action entries. Some embodiments assign other functions of the forwarding element to unit memories within the grid as well, including statistics, meters, state, ternary indirection, etc. In some embodiments, the match memories are segregated (assigned to a specific set of columns, such as those closest to the ALUs) while the remaining memories in the grid are used for implementing memories for other functions (statistics, meters, etc.).

(64) Each match entry of some embodiments includes two portions: the set of match conditions for a packet to meet, and an address of the action entry to read when the set of match conditions is met by a packet. The address, in some embodiments, specifies both a memory page that indicates a unit memory within the grid of unit memories, and a location within that memory page.

(65) FIG. 7 conceptually illustrates a grid **700** of unit memories in some embodiments. Specifically, this example shows 96 unit memories arranged in 16 logical rows, with each row associated with an arithmetic logic unit (ALU) **715**. The **16** logical rows are divided into two separate grids **705** and **710** of eight rows, having six columns in each of the two separate grids. It should be understood that the arrangement of memories shown in FIG. 7 is only one of many examples of the possible arrangements of unit memories to implement match-action tables in a forwarding element, and that the inventive concepts described herein are applicable to many such arrangements.

(66) These unit memories, in some embodiments, each have a number of memory locations, or “words” that can be read by the ALUs. The wiring that allows ALUs to read from several different rows is described in detail in the U.S. Provisional Application 62/108,409, filed Jan. 27, 2015, which is incorporated herein by reference. As shown for one of the unit memories **720**, each memory includes N locations, from Word 0 to Word N-1. In some embodiments, these locations each have a fixed width based on the specific unit memories used in the grid **700**, such as 64 bits, 128 bits, 256 bits, etc. The ALUs **715** in some embodiments read one memory location per unit memory in a given clock cycle.

(67) In some embodiments, each of the unit memories has a designated function. For instance, a first unit memory might store match entries, while a second unit memory stores the action entries that correspond to the match entries of the first unit memory. In addition, the unit memories may store other data for a match-action based forwarding element, including meters (used to measure data flow rates) and statistics (e.g., counters for counting packets, bytes, etc.).

(68) Referring back to FIG. 5, the match-action table of the MAU includes a match entry to match the identification of each egress link. Matching the link identification and performing of the corresponding action (if there is a match) is performed by one of the ALUs. The corresponding

action entry causes the ALU to use the failed link identification included in the packet and compute an index to the status bit of the failed link in the live link vector table. The action also causes the ALU to set the bit to off (i.e., to indicate that the link has failed). After the live link vector table is updated, the packet is not needed and is dropped without being sent out from one of the egress ports **550**.

(69) FIG. **8** conceptually illustrates a process **800** for assigning status bits to a forwarding element's egress links and programming match-action entries to set the status of a failed link to failed. Process **800** in some embodiments is performed when the hardware forwarding element is deployed and an initial set of egress links are configured. The process is also performed each time a new link is configured in order to update the match-action table.

(70) As shown, the process assigns (at **805**) a status bit in the link status table (e.g., the live link vector table **410** in FIG. **4**) for each configured egress link of the forwarding element. As described above, the link status table in some embodiments is stored in dual port memory that is capable of being written by either hardware or software. The process also optionally sets the status of all links to operational (e.g., sets the status bits to 1).

(71) For each configured egress link, the process creates (at **810**) a match field in a match-action table of the MAU to match the identification of the link. Next, for each configured egress link, the process creates (at **815**) the corresponding action to (i) determine the location of the link's status bit in the link status table based on the link identification in a predetermined field of the packet header, (ii) set the status of the link in the link status table to failed (e.g., to set the bit to 0), and (iii) drop the packet after the bit in the link status table is updated. The process then ends.

(72) Process **800** in some embodiments utilizes a programming language that is designed to program packet forwarding data planes in order to program the match-action table. For instance, some embodiments utilize a programming language such as P4, which is used for programming protocol-independent packet processors. P4 language works in conjunction with protocols such as OpenFlow and is designed to program the match-action tables.

(73) FIG. **9** conceptually illustrates the steps hardware forwarding element **505** of FIG. **5** takes to mark a failed link in data plane in some embodiments. The figure shows the ingress pipeline of the forwarding element. As shown, packet generator **510** receives the identification **525** of a failed egress link (i.e. a failed egress path or port). The packet generator generates a packet **905** that includes the identification of the failed link (or the failed port) in a predetermined field of the packet header. In other words, the packet includes a specific signature for the failed link that is used to match a preprogrammed match field of a match-action table in the MAU. The packet is then placed into the packet pipeline of the forwarding element through the packet generator port **520**. The parser **150** then parses the packet header and creates a PHV. One of the registers or containers in the PHV includes the identification of the failed link.

(74) FIG. **10** conceptually illustrates generation of a PHV by a parser from a packet that is generated by a packet generator in some embodiments. As shown, the packet generator **510** generates a packet **905** that includes the identification of the failed link in a predetermined field **1005** of the packet header **1010**. In this example, other fields of the packet header do not include relevant information.

(75) When a packet is received by the parser **150**, the parser parses the packet headers into the PHV **1025**. However, not every header field of each packet header is needed by the MAU stages of the upcoming ingress or egress pipeline to which the parser sends the PHV. For instance, some of the packet header fields will (i) not be matched against by any of the match entries of the match tables in the pipeline and (ii) not be modified by any possible action entry that could be performed in the pipeline. Thus, as the parser **150** extracts each packet header from a packet, the parser determines which of the header fields of the packet header might be processed by at least one of the match-action stages of the MAU.

(76) The illustrated example shows that a packet header **1015** of the packet **905** includes several

participating header fields **1005-1010** that the MAU is configured (e.g., by a configurator module of the control plane) to potentially process. At the same time, the packet header **1015** also includes several other non-participating header fields **1020** that the MAU is not configured to process. In some embodiments, when the parser **150** extracts a particular packet header from a packet, the parser must extract the entire contiguous packet header at once (i.e., the parser cannot leave certain fields of a packet header in the payload while placing the other fields of the packet header in the PHV). Because the different participating header fields of the packet header are often not placed next to each other in the packet header (as illustrated in the figure), the parser of some embodiments separates these participating header fields from nonparticipating fields during extraction of the packet header.

(77) For example, the MAU might be configured to process only a particular set of header fields in a UDP packet header, which may not be the first two header fields of the packet header (i.e., the source and destination ports). In such a case, the parser locates the particular header fields in the set, pulls these fields out of the packet header, and stores the header fields in the PHV. However, the other nonparticipating header fields that are also extracted from the packet have to be dealt with as well. Therefore, in some embodiments, the parser looks at each header field in the packet header and determines whether the identified header field might be processed by the MAU or will definitely not be processed by the MAU.

(78) If the parser **150** determines that the header field is one of the participating header fields, the parser stores the header field in the PHV **1025** (i.e., in a particular set of registers or containers of the PHV **1025** designated for that header field). On the other hand, if the parser determines that the identified header field is not supposed to be processed by the MAU, the parser stores the header field in a separate structure (not shown) that is subsequently sent directly to the deparser of the pipeline without getting processed.

(79) The parser of some embodiments determines which fields of each packet header may be processed and which fields will not be processed by the MAU, based on the information the parser receives from the packet itself (e.g., by one or more particular packet header of the packet), and based on the configuration data that is received, for example, from a compiler in the control plane. In some embodiments, the compiler receives the data required for configuring the pipeline (e.g., through a programming language code such as the above-mentioned P4 language), generates a set of configuration data, and distributes the generated data to a configurator module (also in the control plane). The configurator module then distributes the configuration data to both parser and MAU of the pipeline in the forwarding element (e.g., at run-time or during setup time). For the packet **905** that is generated by the packet generator **510** for the purpose of identifying a failed link, the relevant information **1005** is in a predetermined field of the packet header **1015**. This information is extracted by the parser **150** and is placed in a predetermined register (or container) **1030** of the PHV **1025**.

(80) Referring back to FIG. 9, the PHV passes through the pipeline of match and action stages **915-925**. One of these match-action stages **920** is preprogrammed (e.g., as described above by reference to process **800**) to match the identification of the failed link included in the PHV. The match entry **930** matches the identification of the failed link. The corresponding action entry **935** includes instructions for an ALU **945** (as described above by reference to FIGS. 7 and 8) to (i) determine the location of the link's status bit in the link status table **230** based on the link identification in a predetermined field of the packet header, (ii) set the status of the link in the link status table to failed (e.g., to set the bit to 0), and (iii) drop the packet after the bit in the link status table is updated.

(81) Depending on the particular implementation of the link status table, the action entry causes the ALU to utilize the identification of the link to calculate an index to the link status table **230**. For instance, for the link status table **410** shown in FIG. 4B, the ALU may calculate a pointer to the particular link vector group **415** as well as an offset to the location of the status bit that corresponds

to the failed link.

(82) The ALU in some embodiments is capable of performing operations such as writing into map RAM memory used to store the link status table **140**. The ALU, therefore, sets (as shown by the dashed arrow **940** in FIG. **9**) the status bit **910** that corresponds to the failed link to failed (e.g., to 0). The ALU then drops the packet, as there is not need for the packet to be sent out of an egress port.

(83) FIG. **11** conceptually illustrates a process **1100** that a forwarding element performs in the data plane in order to set the status of a failed link to failed in some embodiments. As shown, different portions of the process are performed by the packet generator, the ingress pipeline parser, and the MAU of the forwarding element.

(84) The process receives (at **1105**) an indication (e.g., as shown by **525** in FIGS. **5** and **9**) that an egress link of the forwarding element has failed. The process then generates (at **1110**) a packet inside the forwarding element (e.g., packet **905** generated by the packet generator **510** in FIG. **9**). The process includes an identification (or signature) of the failed link in the packet header. For instance, the process places the identification in the field **1005** of the packet header **1015** as shown in FIG. **10**.

(85) The process then places (at **1115**) the packet in the packet pipeline of the forwarding element. For instance, the process places packet **905** through the packet pipeline of the forwarding element as shown in FIG. **9**. The process then parses (at **1120**) the packet and places the identification of the failed link in a predetermined register (or container) of the PHV. For instance, the process generates the PHV **1025** and places the identification of the failed link in a register **1030** of the PHV. The process then forwards (at **1125**) the PHV to the MAU.

(86) Next, the process matches (at **1130**) the identification of the failed link in the PHV with the match field of the match-action entry that is preprogrammed to match the link's identification. For instance, the process matches the identification of the failed link with the match field **930** as shown in FIG. **9**.

(87) As described above, each match field has a corresponding action. Once the identification of the failed link matches a match field, the process uses (at **1135**) the action that is preprogrammed for the corresponding ALU to determine the location of the link's status bit in the link status table. For instance, for the link status table **410** shown in FIG. **4B**, the process may calculate a pointer to the particular link vector group **415** as well as an offset to the location of the status bit that corresponds to the failed link.

(88) The process also sets the bit at the determined location to fail. For example, the process sets the status bit **910** to 0 as shown in FIG. **9**. Once the status bit of the failed link is updated in the link status table, the packet is no longer needed and is dropped. The process then ends.

(89) II. Identifying a Failed Egress Port and Selecting a Backup Port in Data Plane

(90) Some embodiments assign a backup port to each egress port. These embodiments, in data plane perform the followings: identify that a primary egress port has failed, mark the failed port, and redirect the packets that were destined to egress from the failed port to the backup port.

Identifying the failed port, marking the failed port, and redirected the packets to the backup port are all done in data plane using hardware and firmware without using the control plane and software.

(91) As described above by reference to FIG. **6**, some embodiments detect a failed port by a MAC unit and send a signal to the traffic manager. The traffic manager sends a signal to the packet generator on the pipeline that corresponds to the failed port. The packet generator then generates a packet to mark the failed port in the link status table. The embodiments that utilize backup ports maintain a data structure (referred to herein as port status table) to keep track of the primary and backup ports.

(92) FIG. **12** conceptually illustrates a port status table of some embodiments maintained in dual port memory that is writable by hardware. As shown, some embodiments utilize an area of memory **1205** (referred to herein as the port status table) for storing the status of the port pairs. The memory

used to store table **1205** in some embodiments is a dual port memory that is capable of being read and written by hardware.

(93) As shown, table **1205** identifies the status **1210** of each primary port and the status **1215** of each backup port. Each port is associated with a flag (e.g., a bit in the table). In the example of FIG. **12**, the status **1220** of a primary port is marked as failed (i.e., set to 0) while the status **1225** of the corresponding backup port is on (i.e., set to 1).

(94) Once a port fails, a typical solution in prior art forwarding elements is for software in control plane to mark the port as failed and select an alternative port to replace the failed port. Utilizing software to mark a port as failed and determine a replacement port is, however, time consuming and slow. Accordingly, some embodiments provide a technique to quickly mark a failed port by performing a set of hardware and firmware operations in the data path and route packets to a backup port without software involvement.

(95) FIG. **13** conceptually illustrates a process **1300** for assigning backup egress ports for a forwarding element and programming match-action entries to set the status of a failed port to failed. Process **1300** in some embodiments is performed when the hardware forwarding element is deployed and an initial set of egress ports are configured. The process is also performed each time a new port is configured in order to update the match-action table.

(96) As shown, the process assigns (at **1305**) a backup port to each configured egress port. The process then assigns (at **1310**) a status bit in a status table (e.g., the port status table **1205** in FIG. **12**) to each configured primary port and each configured backup port. The status table is stored in memory that is capable of being written by either hardware or software. The process also optionally sets the status of all ports to operational (e.g., sets the status bits to 1).

(97) For each configured primary port, the process creates (at **1315**) a match field in a match-action entry to match the identification of the primary port. For each match field created for a configured port, the process creates (at **1320**) an action to (i) identify the location of the status bit of the port in the port status table (ii) set the status of the port in the port status table to failed, and (iii) drop the packet that matched the match-action after the bit in the port status table is updated. The process then ends.

(98) Process **1300** in some embodiments utilizes a programming language that is designed to program packet forwarding data planes in order to program the match-action table. For instance, some embodiments utilize a programming language such as P4, which is used for programming protocol-independent packet processors. P4 language works in conjunction with protocols such as OpenFlow and is designed to program the match-action tables.

(99) FIG. **14** conceptually illustrates the steps a hardware forwarding element **1405** takes to mark a failed port in data plane in some embodiments. The figure shows the ingress pipeline of the forwarding element. As shown, packet generator **510** receives an identification **1490** of a failed egress port. The packet generator generates a packet **1405** that includes the identification of the failed port in a predetermined field of the packet header. In other words, the packet includes a specific signature for the failed port that is used to match a preprogrammed match field of a match-action table in the MAU. The packet is then placed into the packet pipeline of the forwarding element through the packet generator port **520**. The parser **150** then parses the packet header and creates a PHV. One of the registers or containers in the PHV includes the identification of the failed port. For instance, parser includes the identification of the failed port in a register such as register **1030** of PHV as shown in FIG. **10**.

(100) The PHV passes through the pipeline of match and action stages **1415-1425**. One of these match-action stages **1420** is preprogrammed (e.g., as described above by reference to process **1300**) to match the identification of the failed port included in the PHV. The match entry **1430** matches the identification of the failed port. The corresponding action entry **1435** includes instructions for an ALU **1445** (as described above by reference to FIGS. **7** and **13**) to (i) determine the location of the port's status bit in the port status table based on the port identification in a predetermined field

of the packet header, (ii) set the status of the port in the port status table to failed (e.g., to set the bit to 0), and (iii) drop the packet after the bit in the port status table is updated.

(101) Depending on the particular implementation of the port status table, the action entry causes the ALU to utilize the identification of the port to calculate an index to the port status table **1410**. The ALU in some embodiments is capable of performing operations such as writing into map RAM memory used to store the port status table **1410**. The ALU, therefore, sets (as shown by the dashed arrow **1440**) the status bit **1410** that corresponds to the failed port to failed (e.g., to 0). The ALU then drops the packet, as there is not need for the packet to be sent out of an egress port.

(102) Once a primary egress port is marked as failed, packets that specify the failed egress port as their destination port are modified to use the backup port. This process is done in the data plane without using the control plane and software. FIG. **15** conceptually illustrates the steps a hardware forwarding element **1405** takes to replace a failed primary egress port with a backup port in data plane in some embodiments. As shown, a packet **1505** is received through an ingress port **1590**. Packet **1505** is a data packet (also referred to as a user packet) that is received from outside of the forwarding element **1405**. The packet is parsed by parser **150**. The parser places the header fields that might be processed by at least one of the match-action stages **1525-1530** in the PHV.

(103) In the example of FIG. **15**, the egress port identified in the packet **1505** has failed and the associated status bit **1510** in the port status table **1205** has been set to off. The PHV passes through the pipeline of match and action stages **1525-1530**. One of these match-action stages **1520** is preprogrammed to match the identification of the egress port included in the PHV. The match entry **1510** matches the identification of the egress port. The corresponding action entry **1535** includes instructions for an ALU **1545** to (i) determine the location of the port's status bit in the port status table based on the port identification in a predetermined field of the packet header, (ii) check whether the port status is set to failed (e.g., to 0), and (iii) if the port has failed, set the egress port of the packet to the back up port corresponding to the failed port. The packet then proceeds through the ingress and egress pipeline and sent out of the backup egress port.

(104) FIG. **16** conceptually illustrates a process **1600** that a forwarding element performs in the data plane in order to set the status of a failed port to failed in some embodiments. As shown different portions of the process are performed by the packet generator, the parser, and the MAU of the forwarding element.

(105) The process receives (at **1605**) an indication (e.g., as shown by **525** in FIGS. **5** and **14**) that an egress port of the forwarding element has failed. The process then generates (at **1610**) a packet inside the forwarding element (e.g., packet **1405** generated by the packet generator **510** in FIG. **14**). The process includes an identification (or signature) of the failed port in the packet header. For instance, the process places the identification in the field **1005** of the packet header **1015** as shown in FIG. **10**.

(106) The process then places (at **1615**) the packet in the packet pipeline of the forwarding element. For instance, the process places packet **1405** through the packet pipeline of the forwarding element as shown in FIG. **14**. The process then parses (at **1620**) the packet and places the identification of the failed port in a predetermined register (or container) of the PHV. For instance, the process generates the PHV **1025** and places the identification of the failed port in a register **1030** of the PHV. The process then forwards (at **1625**) the PHV to the MAU.

(107) Next, the process matches (at **1630**) the identification of the failed port in the PHV with the match field of the match-action entry that is preprogrammed to match the port's identification. For instance, the process matches the identification of the failed port with the match field **1430** as shown in FIG. **14**.

(108) As described above, each match field has a corresponding action. Once the identification of the failed port matches a match field, the process uses (at **1635**) the action that is preprogrammed for the corresponding ALU to determine the location of the port's status bit in the port status table. For instance, for the port status table **1205** shown in FIG. **12**, the process may calculate an offset to

the location of the status bit that corresponds to the failed port.

(109) The process also sets the bit at the determined location to fail. For example, the process sets the status bit **1410** to 0 as shown in FIG. **14**. Once the status bit of the failed port is updated in the port status table, the packet is no longer needed and is dropped. The process then ends.

(110) III. Computer System

(111) FIG. **17** conceptually illustrates an electronic system **1700** with which some embodiments of the invention are implemented. The electronic system **1700** can be used to execute any of the control, virtualization, or operating system applications described above. The electronic system **1700** may be a computer (e.g., a desktop computer, personal computer, tablet computer, server computer, mainframe, a blade computer etc.), phone, PDA, or any other sort of electronic device. Such an electronic system includes various types of computer readable media and interfaces for various other types of computer readable media. Electronic system **1700** includes a bus **1705**, processing unit(s) **1710**, system memory **1720**, read-only memory (ROM) **1730**, permanent storage device **1735**, input devices **1740**, output devices **1745**, and TCAM **1750**.

(112) The bus **1705** collectively represents all system, peripheral, and chipset buses that communicatively connect the numerous internal devices of the electronic system **1700**. For instance, the bus **1705** communicatively connects the processing unit(s) **1710** with the read-only memory **1730**, the system memory **1720**, and the permanent storage device **1735**.

(113) From these various memory units, the processing unit(s) **1710** retrieve instructions to execute and data to process in order to execute the processes of the invention. The processing unit(s) may be a single processor or a multi-core processor in different embodiments.

(114) The read-only-memory **1730** stores static data and instructions that are needed by the processing unit(s) **1710** and other modules of the electronic system. The permanent storage device **1735**, on the other hand, is a read-and-write memory device. This device is a non-volatile memory unit that stores instructions and data even when the electronic system **1700** is off. Some embodiments of the invention use a mass-storage device (such as a magnetic or optical disk and its corresponding disk drive) as the permanent storage device **1735**.

(115) Other embodiments use a removable storage device (such as a floppy disk, flash drive, etc.) as the permanent storage device. Like the permanent storage device **1735**, the system memory **1720** is a read-and-write memory device. However, unlike storage device **1735**, the system memory is a volatile read-and-write memory, such a random access memory. The system memory stores some of the instructions and data that the processor needs at runtime. In some embodiments, the invention's processes are stored in the system memory **1720**, the permanent storage device **1735**, and/or the read-only memory **1730**. From these various memory units, the processing unit(s) **1710** retrieve instructions to execute and data to process in order to execute the processes of some embodiments.

(116) The bus **1705** also connects to the input and output devices **1740** and **1745**. The input devices enable the user to communicate information and select commands to the electronic system. The input devices **1740** include alphanumeric keyboards and pointing devices (also called "cursor control devices"). The output devices **1745** display images generated by the electronic system. The output devices include printers and display devices, such as cathode ray tubes (CRT) or liquid crystal displays (LCD). Some embodiments include devices such as a touchscreen that function as both input and output devices.

(117) Finally, as shown in FIG. **17**, bus **1705** also couples electronic system **1700** to a network **1725** through a network adapter (not shown). In this manner, the computer can be a part of a network of computers (such as a local area network ("LAN"), a wide area network ("WAN"), or an Intranet, or a network of networks, such as the Internet. Any or all components of electronic system **1700** may be used in conjunction with the invention.

(118) Some embodiments include electronic components, such as microprocessors, storage and memory that store computer program instructions in a machine-readable or computer-readable

medium (alternatively referred to as computer-readable storage media, machine-readable media, or machine-readable storage media). Some examples of such computer-readable media include RAM, ROM, read-only compact discs (CD-ROM), recordable compact discs (CD-R), rewritable compact discs (CD-RW), read-only digital versatile discs (e.g., DVD-ROM, dual-layer DVD-ROM), a variety of recordable/rewritable DVDs (e.g., DVD-RAM, DVD-RW, DVD+RW, etc.), flash memory (e.g., SD cards, mini-SD cards, micro-SD cards, etc.), magnetic and/or solid state hard drives, read-only and recordable Blu-Ray® discs, ultra density optical discs, any other optical or magnetic media, and floppy disks. The computer-readable media may store a computer program that is executable by at least one processing unit and includes sets of instructions for performing various operations. Examples of computer programs or computer code include machine code, such as is produced by a compiler, and files including higher-level code that are executed by a computer, an electronic component, or a microprocessor using an interpreter.

(119) While the above discussion primarily refers to microprocessor or multi-core processors that execute software, some embodiments are performed by one or more integrated circuits, such as application specific integrated circuits (ASICs) or field programmable gate arrays (FPGAs). In some embodiments, such integrated circuits execute instructions that are stored on the circuit itself.

(120) As used in this specification, the terms “computer”, “server”, “processor”, and “memory” all refer to electronic or other technological devices. These terms exclude people or groups of people. For the purposes of the specification, the terms display or displaying means displaying on an electronic device. As used in this specification, the terms “computer readable medium,” “computer readable media,” and “machine readable medium” are entirely restricted to tangible, physical objects that store information in a form that is readable by a computer. These terms exclude any wireless signals, wired download signals, and any other ephemeral or transitory signals.

(121) While the invention has been described with reference to numerous specific details, one of ordinary skill in the art will recognize that the invention can be embodied in other specific forms without departing from the spirit of the invention. In addition, a number of the figures (including FIGS. 8, 11, 13, and 16) conceptually illustrate processes. The specific operations of these processes may not be performed in the exact order shown and described. The specific operations may not be performed in one continuous series of operations, and different specific operations may be performed in different embodiments. Furthermore, the process could be implemented using several sub-processes, or as part of a larger macro process.

(122) In view of the foregoing, one of ordinary skill in the art would understand that the invention is not to be limited by the foregoing illustrative details, but rather is to be defined by the appended claims.

Claims

1. An integrated circuit for use in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising: programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware for use in (1) parsing and identifying header field data of received packet data and (2) matching the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions to be carried out in processing of the packet data, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware comprising ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware; and shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware for use in (1) storing at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware and (2) providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware are configurable to comprise respective pluralities of pipelines; when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the

identifying, and the programmable match-action table data are programmable based upon software-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmission, the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative tunnel-related transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to implement the one or more packet processing-related actions; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate flow-related information and statistics-related information usable in association with software-defined networking; the flow-related information is configurable to comprise data flow rate information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

2. The integrated circuit of claim 1, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store the programmable match-action table data.

3. The integrated circuit of claim 2, wherein: the primary and the alternative tunnel-related transmission paths are associated with respective ports and/or respective links that are associated with the integrated circuit.

4. The integrated circuit of claim 3, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is for use in association with another integrated circuit.

5. At least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium storing instructions for being executed by an integrated circuit, the integrated circuit to be used in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware and shared buffer memory, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware comprising ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware, the instructions, when executed by the integrated circuit, resulting in the integrated circuit being configured for performance of operations comprising: parsing and identifying, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, header field data of received packet data; matching, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions to be carried out in processing of the packet data; storing, in the shared buffer memory, at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware; and providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware are configurable to comprise respective pluralities of pipelines; when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, and the programmable match-action table data are programmable based upon software-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmission, the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative tunnel-related transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to implement the one or more packet processing-related actions; the one or more packet processing-related actions are

configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate flow-related information and statistics-related information usable in association with software-defined networking; the flow-related information is configurable to comprise data flow rate information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

6. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 5, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store the programmable match-action table data.

7. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 6, wherein: the primary and the alternative tunnel-related transmission paths are associated with respective ports and/or respective links that are associated with the integrated circuit.

8. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 7, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is for use in association with another integrated circuit.

9. A method implemented using an integrated circuit, the integrated circuit to be used in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware and shared buffer memory, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware comprising ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware, the method comprising: parsing and identifying, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, header field data of received packet data; matching, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions to be carried out in processing of the packet data; storing, in the shared buffer memory, at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware; and providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware are configurable to comprise respective pluralities of pipelines; when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, and the programmable match-action table data are programmable based upon software-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmission, the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative tunnel-related transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to implement the one or more packet processing-related actions; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate flow-related information and statistics-related information usable in association with software-defined networking; the flow-related information is configurable to comprise data flow rate information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

10. The method of claim 9, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store the programmable match-action table data.

11. The method of claim 10, wherein: the primary and the alternative tunnel-related transmission paths are associated with respective ports and/or respective links that are associated with the integrated circuit.

12. The method of claim 11, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific

integrated circuit (ASIC) that is for use in association with another integrated circuit.

13. A network switch for use in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the network switch comprising: ports to be communicatively coupled to the network; and an integrated circuit communicatively coupled to the ports, the integrated circuit comprising: programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware for use in (1) parsing and identifying header field data of received packet data and (2) matching the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions to be carried out in processing of the packet data, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware comprising ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware; and shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware for use in (1) storing at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware and (2) providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware are configurable to comprise respective pluralities of pipelines; when the network switch is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, and the programmable match-action table data are programmable based upon software-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmission, the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative tunnel-related transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to implement the one or more packet processing-related actions; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate flow-related information and statistics-related information usable in association with software-defined networking; the flow-related information is configurable to comprise data flow rate information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

14. The network switch of claim 13, wherein: the network switch comprises ternary content addressable memory to store the programmable match-action table data.

15. The network switch of claim 14, wherein: the primary and the alternative tunnel-related transmission paths are associated with respective of the ports of the network switch and/or respective links that are associated with the respective of the ports.

16. The network switch of claim 15, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is for use in association with another integrated circuit.

17. An integrated circuit for use in association with a network forwarding element in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising: programmable packet processor device for use in (1) parsing and identifying header field data of received packet data and (2) matching the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions to be carried out in processing of the packet data, the programmable packet processor device comprising ingress and egress pipelines; and shared storage to be shared between the ingress pipeline and the egress pipeline for use in (1) storing at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline and (2) providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared storage to the egress pipeline; wherein: the ingress pipeline and the egress pipeline are configurable to comprise respective pluralities of pipelines; when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, and the programmable match-action table data are programmable based upon software-generated

configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmissions the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative tunnel- related transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to implement the one or more packet processing-related actions; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate flow-related information and statistics- related information usable in association with software-defined networking; the flow-related information is configurable to comprise data flow rate information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

18. The integrated circuit of claim 17, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable storage to store the programmable match-action table data.

19. The integrated circuit of claim 18, wherein: the primary and the alternative tunnel-related transmission paths are associated with respective ports and/or respective links that are associated with the integrated circuit.

20. The integrated circuit of claim 19, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is for use in association with another integrated circuit.

21. An integrated circuit for use in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising: programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware configurable to comprise ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware to be used in: (1) parsing and identifying header field data of received packet data; (2) matching the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions being configurable to comprise modifying, at least in part, the header field data to generate modified header data; and (3) generating, at a deparser stage of the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, based upon the header field data and the modified header data, output packet data to be output from the integrated circuit; and shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware for use in (1) storing at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware and (2) providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, the programmable match-action table data, and the generating are programmable based upon compiler-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmissions the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to maintain port status information associated with the integrated circuit for use in association with the at least one data structure; the at least one alternative path is configurable to be associated with link aggregation; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate statistics-related information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise

packet count information and/or byte count information.

22. The integrated circuit of claim 21, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store, at least in part, the programmable match-action table data.

23. The integrated circuit of claim 22, wherein: the primary and the alternative transmission paths are associated with respective ports that are associated with the integrated circuit.

24. The integrated circuit of claim 23, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is comprised in the network switch.

25. At least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium storing instructions for being executed by an integrated circuit, the integrated circuit to be used in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware and shared buffer memory, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware being configurable to comprise ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware, the instructions, when executed by the integrated circuit, resulting in the integrated circuit being configured for performance of operations comprising: parsing and identifying, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, header field data of received packet data; matching, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions being configurable to comprise modifying, at least in part, the header field data to generate modified header data; generating, at a deparser stage of the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, based upon the header field data and the modified header data, output packet data to be output from the integrated circuit; storing, in the shared buffer memory, at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware; and providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, the programmable match-action table data, and the generating are programmable based upon compiler-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmissions the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to maintain port status information associated with the integrated circuit for use in association with the at least one data structure; the at least one alternative path is configurable to be associated with link aggregation; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate statistics-related information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

26. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 25, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store, at least in part, the programmable match-action table data.

27. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 26, wherein: the primary and the alternative transmission paths are associated with respective ports that are associated with the integrated circuit.

28. The at least one non-transitory machine-readable storage medium of claim 27, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is comprised in the network switch.

29. A method implemented using an integrated circuit, the integrated circuit to be used in association with a network switch in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the integrated circuit comprising programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware and shared buffer memory, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware being configurable to comprise ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the shared buffer memory to be shared between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware, the method comprising: parsing and identifying, by the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, header field data of received packet data; matching, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions being configurable to comprise modifying, at least in part, the header field data to generate modified header data; generating, at a deparser stage of the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, based upon the header field data and the modified header data, output packet data to be output from the integrated circuit; storing, in the shared buffer memory, at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware; and providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, the programmable match-action table data, and the generating are programmable based upon compiler-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmission, the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to maintain port status information associated with the integrated circuit for use in association with the at least one data structure; the at least one alternative path is configurable to be associated with link aggregation; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate statistics-related information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

30. The method of claim 29, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store, at least in part, the programmable match-action table data.

31. The method of claim 30, wherein: the primary and the alternative transmission paths are associated with respective ports that are associated with the integrated circuit.

32. The method of claim 31, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is comprised in the network switch.

33. A network switch for use in packet forwarding-related operations in a network, the network switch comprising: ports to be communicatively coupled to the network; and an integrated circuit communicatively coupled to the ports, the integrated circuit comprising: programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware configurable to comprise ingress pipeline hardware and egress pipeline hardware, the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware to be used in: (1) parsing and identifying header field data of received packet data; (2) matching the header field data to programmable match-action table data to determine one or more packet processing-related actions that correspond to the header field data, the one or more packet processing-related actions being configurable to comprise modifying, at least in part, the header field data to generate modified header data; and (3) generating, at a deparser stage of the programmable packet data processing pipeline hardware, based upon the header field data and the modified header data, output packet data to be output from the integrated circuit; and shared buffer memory to be shared

between the ingress pipeline hardware and the egress pipeline hardware for use in (1) storing at least one portion of the received packet data sent from the ingress pipeline hardware and (2) providing the at least one portion of the received packet data stored in the shared buffer memory to the egress pipeline hardware; wherein: when the integrated circuit is in operation: the parsing, the identifying, the programmable match-action table data, and the generating are programmable based upon compiler-generated configuration data to be provided to the integrated circuit; in event of failure of at least one path for packet data transmission, the integrated circuit is configurable to select, based upon at least one data structure maintained at a data plane of the integrated circuit, at least one alternative path for the packet data transmissions the at least one path and/or the at least one alternative path being configurable to correspond to multiple respective network hops from the network switch, wherein the at least one alternative path is for use in association with multi-path transmission; the at least one data structure is configurable to indicate primary and alternative transmission paths for use in the packet data transmission; the integrated circuit is to maintain port status information associated with the integrated circuit for use in association with the at least one data structure; the at least one alternative path is configurable to be associated with link aggregation; the one or more packet processing-related actions are configurable to comprise: one or more equal-cost multi-path routing operations; the integrated circuit is configurable to generate statistics-related information; and the statistics-related information is configurable to comprise packet count information and/or byte count information.

34. The network switch of claim 33, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises ternary content addressable memory to store, at least in part, the programmable match-action table data.

35. The network switch of claim 34, wherein: the primary and the alternative transmission paths are associated with respective ports that are associated with the integrated circuit.

36. The network switch of claim 35, wherein: the integrated circuit comprises an application specific integrated circuit (ASIC) that is comprised in the network switch.
